

Opal

*There are opals on Mars!
They show up in photographs of
the surface of the red planet.*



Fire opal



Precious opal



White opal

Opals are rain made solid. Sometimes, when rain drips into rock, the water carries dissolved minerals into the cracks. Very slowly, these grow into an opal, but it takes many thousands of years. Some of the liquid also remains locked inside the gem — up to a tenth of an opal is water.

Turn an opal around in your hands and it can look like it is on fire inside. Seen from different directions, light is reflected as yellows, oranges, blues, or greens. The Ancient Greeks thought that opals were the tears of Zeus, the king of the gods. After winning a battle, he wept tears of joy, and as they hit the ground they became opals.